AIRINDEX · PRE-FEASIBILITY SNAPSHOT

Charlotte UAM Market Readiness

Charlotte Metro · Charlotte Douglas International Airport (CLT) · Mecklenburg County

Prepared for
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Confidential

CURRENT SCORE	NATIONAL RANK	STATE LEGISLATION	PATH TO MODERATE
35	**#10**	**None**	**+15**
/ 100 · EARLY	of 21 scored markets	No NC UAM framework	points needed · 50 threshold

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Charlotte scores 35/100 on the AirIndex Market Readiness Index — **EARLY tier**, ranking #10 nationally. The market has genuine demand-side strengths that most EARLY-tier markets lack: CLT is the 6th busiest airport in the US, the banking and finance concentration creates natural executive shuttle demand, and Charlotte is the fastest-growing major city in the Southeast. NC DOT's participation in the FAA AAM Integration Pilot Program is a meaningful federal signal. **The constraint is structural: no state legislation, no operator commitment, and no vertiport infrastructure.** The demand case is strong — the supply-side framework hasn't caught up.

SEVEN-FACTOR READINESS BREAKDOWN

FACTOR	WEIGHT	SCORE	STATUS & SOURCE
Active Pilot Program	20	**20**	**ACTIVE.** NC DOT joined the FAA Advanced Air Mobility Integration Pilot Program for electric aircraft testing (2026). This is the highest-weight factor in the index and Charlotte's strongest scoring signal.

FACTOR	WEIGHT	SCORE	STATUS & SOURCE
Approved Vertiport	20	**0**	**GAP.** No vertiport has received regulatory approval in the Charlotte metro area. CLT airport long-range plan references UAM but no specific vertiport development project has advanced to permitting.
Active Operator Presence	15	**0**	**GAP.** No eVTOL operator has announced or commenced operations in the Charlotte market. Joby, Archer, Wisk, and Lilium have no visible presence. Operator commitment typically follows legislative framework and infrastructure investment signals.
Vertiport Zoning	15	**0**	**GAP.** No municipal or county zoning framework accommodates vertiport infrastructure. Mecklenburg County and the City of Charlotte have no UAM-specific land-use provisions on record.
Regulatory Posture	10	**5**	**NEUTRAL.** Charlotte Future Mobility Task Force formed — signals awareness and engagement. NC DOT's federal pilot program participation demonstrates state-level proactive positioning. However, no formal pro-AAM city resolution or ordinance has been adopted.
State Legislation	10	**0**	**NONE.** No UAM or AAM enabling legislation found in North Carolina. No bills introduced, no framework under development. This is the single most important gap — state legislation is the prerequisite that unlocks every downstream factor.
LAANC Coverage	10	**10**	**CONFIRMED.** FAA LAANC Authorization active for Charlotte Douglas area airspace. Automated near-real-time authorization for UAS operations in controlled airspace.

Total: 35 / 100 · 2 of 7 factors at full credit **65 points of available upside**

GAP ANALYSIS: PATH TO MODERATE (50+) AND BEYOND

Charlotte needs **15 additional points** to reach MODERATE tier (50/100) and **40 points** to reach FRIENDLY (75+). The gap profile is clear: Charlotte has the demand case and federal engagement — it lacks the supply-side framework.

+10 pts
LEG

State Legislation: None → Enacted

This is the gating factor. No UAM legislation exists in North Carolina — not introduced, not in committee, not in draft. Every market that has reached ADVANCED tier passed state enabling legislation first. Texas HB 1735 (2023), Florida's AAM Act (2024), and California's SB 944 are the templates. NC DOT's federal engagement through the AAM pilot program creates a natural legislative proof point — the state agency is already participating, the legal framework needs to follow. A single bill introducing a UAM framework would move Charlotte from 35 to 45 immediately.

Priority: CRITICAL · This unlocks every downstream gap

+15 pts
OPS

Active Operator Presence: None → 1+

No eVTOL operator has committed to Charlotte. This is not unusual at EARLY tier — operators follow legislative signals and infrastructure investment. Charlotte's demand profile (6th busiest US airport, banking/finance concentration, Southeast growth) is exactly what operators target. The pattern across ADVANCED markets: legislation → operator announcement within 12–18 months. Joby, Archer, and Wisk are all expanding US market footprints.

Likelihood: HIGH post-legislation · Timeline: 12–18 months after framework enacted

+15 pts
ZONE

Vertiport Zoning: None → Adopted

No municipal or county zoning framework for vertiport infrastructure. CLT airport's long-range plan references UAM — this means the conversation has started at the airport authority level. Municipal zoning adoption typically follows state legislation by 6–12 months (Dallas adopted vertiport zoning within 6 months of HB 1735). Mecklenburg County would need UAM-specific land-use provisions.

Likelihood: MEDIUM · Timeline: 6–12 months post-legislation

+20 pts
VERT

Approved Vertiport: 0 → 1+

The largest single-factor gap. Requires zoning framework first, then site selection, feasibility study, environmental review, and FAA approval. CLT's existing general aviation infrastructure and the airport's UAM-referenced long-range plan provide a head start. A DOT RAISE-funded feasibility study would be the logical first step.

Likelihood: MEDIUM · Timeline: 24–36 months

+5 pts
REG

Regulatory Posture: Neutral → Friendly

The Charlotte Future Mobility Task Force and NC DOT's federal engagement signal awareness. A formal city council resolution supporting AAM operations or a Charlotte-specific AAM strategic plan would upgrade the posture from Neutral to Friendly.

Likelihood: HIGH · Timeline: Near-term (lowest-effort gap to close)

LEGISLATION INTRODUCED
+5 LEG (actively moving) + 5 REG (posture)
45
EARLY

LEGISLATION ENACTED
+10 LEG + 5 REG + operator follows
65
MODERATE

FULL FRAMEWORK
All gaps closed
100
ADVANCED

WHAT HIGHER TIERS LOOK LIKE

MODERATE tier (50–74) is where markets transition from positioning to active development. ADVANCED tier (75–100) is where infrastructure investment conversations become actionable and operators commit capital. Here's what the peer markets that have crossed these thresholds look like:

Dallas–Fort Worth — 100

ADVANCED · #1 nationally

✓ TX HB 1735 — landmark UAM legislation (2023)
✓ City of Dallas vertiport zoning code amendment
✓ 2 approved vertiports under construction
✓ Wisk Aero autonomous flight testing active
✓ Pro-innovation regulatory framework

Sequence: State legislation (2023) → municipal zoning (6 mo) → vertiport approvals (18 mo) → operator commitment. Every step followed the legislative catalyst.

Orlando — 85

ADVANCED · #4 nationally

✓ Florida AAM Act — statewide enabling legislation
✓ Orange County vertiport zoning adopted
✓ Lake Nona vertiport permitted (FDOT-funded)
✓ Lake Nona smart city UAM pilot program
✓ FDOT actively supporting AAM infrastructure

Southeast peer. Similar growth profile. Florida's AAM Act created the framework — FDOT funding followed, then vertiport permitting, then the pilot program. Tourism corridor (MCO–Disney) identified as premium route.

Phoenix, AZ — the closest comparable right now — 55

MODERATE · #5 nationally

Phoenix was at 40 two months ago — similar to Charlotte's current position. What moved it: Arizona introduced three coordinated AAM bills (SB1827, SB1819, SB1826) and Joby expanded testing operations into the market. Charlotte has the pilot program that Phoenix has, but lacks the legislative momentum Arizona has built. **The Phoenix trajectory is the model for what Charlotte's next 12 months could look like if NC introduces enabling legislation.**

The Charlotte advantage: 6th busiest US airport, banking/finance executive shuttle demand, fastest-growing Southeast metro, and NC DOT already at the federal table through the AAM pilot program. The demand case doesn't need to be built — it exists. The supply-side framework is the missing piece.

THE NORTH CAROLINA LEGISLATION GAP

North Carolina is one of the few states with active federal AAM engagement (through NC DOT's pilot program) but no state-level enabling legislation. This creates an asymmetry: the federal signal is strong, but operators and infrastructure developers cannot act without the state legal framework.

STATES WITH ENACTED LEGISLATION

Texas — HB 1735 (2023). Result: Dallas 100, Houston 55, Austin 55.

Florida — AAM Act (2024). Result: Miami 80, Orlando 85.

California — SB 944. Result: Los Angeles 100, San Francisco 75, San Diego 45.

STATES WITH LEGISLATION MOVING

Arizona — SB1827 + SB1819 + SB1826 (2026). Result: Phoenix jumped from 40 to 55 during legislative session.

Ohio, **Illinois** — Early-stage bills introduced.

NORTH CAROLINA: NO LEGISLATION

NC DOT is at the federal table. Charlotte has the demand profile. CLT airport's long-range plan references UAM. The Charlotte Future Mobility Task Force exists. But without a state enabling framework, operators have no legal certainty, developers have no zoning pathway, and the federal engagement cannot convert into infrastructure investment. **One bill changes Charlotte's trajectory.**

THE CHARLOTTE DEMAND CASE

Most EARLY-tier markets have a supply-side problem and a demand-side problem. Charlotte has only the supply-side problem.

#6
Busiest US airport by passenger volume

Banking HQ
Dense finance/banking executive shuttle demand

#1
Fastest-growing major city in the Southeast

FAA

NC DOT in FAA AAM
Integration Pilot Program

FEDERAL PROGRAMS — CHARLOTTE GAP MATCH

The following federal programs map directly to Charlotte's current gap profile. This is not a recommendation — it is a data layer showing which programs have funded similar gap-closing activity in peer markets, and what the current cycle status is.

PROGRAM	GAP ADDRESSED	PEER MARKET PRECEDENT	CYCLE
White House AAM Pilot Program	PLT (+20 pts)	Miami, Dallas, LA all achieved ADVANCED tier following selection. NC DOT's existing FAA pilot program participation is directly relevant — it demonstrates community preparedness at the state level. Charlotte's airport volume and growth profile align with selection criteria.	See DOT AAM National Strategy (Dec 2025)
DOT RAISE Grants	VRT (+20 pts) ZONE (+15 pts)	Vertiport feasibility studies are explicitly RAISE-eligible. Orlando's FDOT-funded Lake Nona study followed this pathway. CLT's long-range UAM reference and NC DOT's federal engagement create a strong multimodal narrative for a feasibility application.	2026 cycle typically Q1–Q2
FAA eVTOL Integration Pilot Program (eIPP)	PLT (+20 pts) REG (+5 pts)	Phoenix applied jointly with Arizona Commerce Authority — the CLT Alliance / NC DOT partnership could follow a similar model. Selection is a PLT and REG scoring signal. CLT's Class B airspace and existing infrastructure align with candidate criteria.	Rolling

PEER MARKET COMPARISON

FACTOR	CHARLOTTE 35 · EARLY	DALLAS 100 · ADVANCED	ORLANDO 85 · ADVANCED	PHOENIX 55 · MODERATE
Pilot Program	20 / 20	20 / 20	20 / 20	20 / 20
Approved Vertiport	0 / 20	20 / 20	20 / 20	0 / 20
Operator Presence	0 / 15	15 / 15	0 / 15	15 / 15
Vertiport Zoning	0 / 15	15 / 15	15 / 15	0 / 15
Regulatory Posture	5 / 10	10 / 10	10 / 10	5 / 10

FACTOR	CHARLOTTE 35 · EARLY	DALLAS 100 · ADVANCED	ORLANDO 85 · ADVANCED	PHOENIX 55 · MODERATE
State Legislation	0 / 10	10 / 10	10 / 10	5 / 10
LAANC Coverage	10 / 10	10 / 10	10 / 10	10 / 10
TOTAL	35	100	85	55

Key insight: Charlotte matches or exceeds Phoenix on pilot program engagement and LAANC coverage. The 20-point gap between them is entirely legislation (+5) and operator presence (+15). Phoenix has both because Arizona started the legislative process — operators followed the signal. Charlotte's demand profile is arguably stronger than Phoenix's. The legislative gap is the entire story.

METHODOLOGY

AirIndex scores U.S. metro markets on UAM readiness using seven weighted factors totaling 100 points. All data is traced to primary sources: FAA LAANC (UAS Facility Map), Federal Register (regulatory notices), LegiScan (state legislation tracking), and SEC EDGAR (operator filings). An AI classification layer parses incoming signals for factor relevance, with human review at multiple confidence tiers. Scores update automatically when qualifying events are detected and verified.

The model measures *current verified conditions*, not predictions. It does not forecast commercialization timelines, assess operator financial viability, or evaluate aviation safety outcomes. Scores reflect the regulatory, legislative, infrastructure, and operator conditions that determine market readiness for commercial eVTOL operations.

Full methodology: **airindex.io/methodology** · Classification accuracy: ~89% (March 2026 audit)

This snapshot was generated by AirIndex for Alyssa Brown Moseley, CLT Alliance. Data sourced from FAA LAANC (UAS Facility Map), NC General Assembly, LegiScan, SEC EDGAR, Federal Register, and the AirIndex Scored Market Index (21 markets). Scores reflect current verified conditions as of March 20, 2026. For full methodology: airindex.io/methodology · alan@airindex.io